Baptized into Christ

Jesus commanded baptism for his disciples and it speaks of our union with Christ; Christians share these truths while differing honestly over who should be baptized, how, and what baptism does.

Main passage	Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:3-4 (KJV)
Topic	Baptism
Version	All views (contested point: Baptism)
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Commanded by Christ for his disciples	6 min
Teaching point 2: Baptized into Christ's death and resurrection	6 min
Teaching point 3: Called to walk in newness of life	4 min
Where Christians differ	8 min
Discussion questions	5 min
Application	2 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask the class, if they are comfortable sharing: "Do you remember your baptism, or have you been told about it? What do you remember, or what were you told?" Some will remember a river or a baptistry; others were baptized as babies and have only photographs. Some may not have been baptized at all. Explain that baptism is something Jesus commanded, and today we look at what it means.

Teacher note: Be gentle with anyone who has not been baptized or whose experience differs from the class's. The goal is understanding, not embarrassment.

Scripture (3 min)

Matthew 28:18-20

18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.

19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Romans 6:3-4

3 Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? 4 Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life.

Read both passages aloud: first Jesus' command (Matthew 28:18-20), then Paul's explanation of what baptism means (Romans 6:3-4).

Background (5 min)

Matthew 28:18-20, often called the Great Commission, are Jesus' last words in Matthew's Gospel. With all authority in heaven and earth, he sends his followers to make disciples of all nations, "baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost," and teaching them to obey all he commanded.

In Romans 6 Paul answers a question: if we are saved by grace, should we keep on sinning? His answer points to baptism. Those baptized into Christ were baptized into his death, and they are to walk in "newness of life." Christians in every tradition treasure these verses, even where they understand baptism's details differently.

Teaching point 1: Commanded by Christ for his disciples (6 min)

Baptism was not invented by the church. Jesus himself commanded it, as part of making disciples of all nations, in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Christians of every tradition baptize because Jesus told us to, and they use these words.

Supporting verses

Matthew 28:18-20: And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Acts 2:41: Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls.

Acts 8:12: But when they believed Philip preaching the things concerning the kingdom of God, and the name of Jesus Christ, they were baptized, both men and women.

> *“Baptism consists in applying water to a person "in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Ghost," as Christ has commanded.”*
>
> — Joseph Stump, An Explanation of Luther's Small Catechism, “What Baptism is”

Handout blanks (answers)

Baptize them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy **Ghost (Spirit)**.

Christians baptize because **Jesus** commanded it.

Teaching point 2: Baptized into Christ's death and resurrection (6 min)

Paul says that "so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death" (Romans 6:3). Baptism is about union with Christ: belonging to him, sharing in what his death and resurrection accomplished, and being marked as his.

Supporting verses

Romans 6:3-4: Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life.

Galatians 3:27: For as many of you as have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ.

Colossians 2:12: Buried with him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised him from the dead.

> *“sealed with the seal of heaven, and as it were formally entered and articled, to all the benefits and all the obligations of Christian discipleship”*
>
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Romans 6:3

> *“To be baptized into Christ, is to receive the doctrine of Christ crucified”*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Romans 6:3

Handout blanks (answers)

So many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his **death**.

Baptism speaks of our **union** with Christ.

Teaching point 3: Called to walk in newness of life (4 min)

Baptism looks forward as well as back. "Like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life" (Romans 6:4). Whatever our tradition, the baptized are called to live as people who belong to the risen Christ.

Supporting verses

Romans 6:4-11 (read from the Bible)

2 Corinthians 5:17: Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.

Colossians 3:1-3: If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God. Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth. For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God.

> *"by our very profession made in baptism we have renounced sin, and have pledged ourselves to live to God."*
>
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Romans 6:3

Handout blanks (answers)

We also should walk in **newness** of life.

The baptized are called to live as people who belong to the risen **Christ**.

Where Christians differ (8 min)

Christians agree that Jesus commanded baptism, that it is done with water in the name of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit, that it is linked with repentance, faith, forgiveness and union with Christ, and that true baptism is not repeated. They differ on three questions: who should be baptized (believers only, or also the children of believers), how (immersion, or also pouring and sprinkling), and what baptism does (a means through which God gives grace, a sign and seal of his covenant, or an act of obedience that testifies to grace already received). Here are the main views of the five traditions, each described as its own teachers describe it. Sincere, Bible-believing Christians hold each of them.

Baptist

Baptists teach "believer's baptism": baptism is for those who have personally repented and put their faith in Christ, and it is done by immersing the whole body in water, picturing death, burial and resurrection with Christ. Baptism is an ordinance of obedience and a public confession of faith; it does not itself save or convey grace, but follows salvation. Because infants cannot yet believe, they are not baptized; many Baptist churches hold a service of dedication instead, and a person baptized as an infant is baptized as a believer.

Key texts: Matthew 28:19-20; Acts 2:41; Acts 8:36-38; Romans 6:3-4; Colossians 2:12

Methodist and Wesleyan

Methodists and Wesleyans treat baptism as a sacrament: an outward sign of an inward grace and a means by which God works. It marks entry into the church and God's covenant, and it is given both to adults who come to faith and to the infants of Christian families. Pouring or sprinkling is usual, though immersion is also accepted. John Wesley linked baptism with the new birth, but taught that every baptized person must still personally turn to Christ and be born of the Spirit; baptized children are later confirmed in their own profession of faith.

Key texts: Acts 2:38-39; Mark 10:13-16; Colossians 2:11-12; Titus 3:5

Presbyterian and Reformed

Presbyterian and Reformed churches teach that baptism is a sacrament, a sign and seal of God's covenant of grace, which in the New Testament takes the place of circumcision. It is given to those who profess faith and also to the children of believing parents, because God's covenant promise is "unto you, and to your children" (Acts 2:39). Sprinkling or pouring is usual and immersion is valid. The grace signified is not tied to the moment of baptism and is received by faith; baptism does not automatically regenerate, and it is administered only once.

Key texts: Genesis 17:7-12; Colossians 2:11-12; Acts 2:38-39; Acts 16:14-15, 31-33; 1 Corinthians 7:14

Lutheran

Lutherans teach that baptism is a means of grace: not simply water, but water joined to God's command and promise. Through it God gives forgiveness of sins, rescue from death and the devil, and eternal salvation to all who believe. Faith receives the gift, and God works faith even in infants through his Word, so children are baptized. The Augsburg Confession calls baptism necessary to salvation (while Lutherans do not teach that the unbaptized who believe are lost). Pouring is the usual mode. The baptized person returns daily to baptism by repentance and faith.

Key texts: Mark 16:16; Matthew 28:19; Titus 3:5; Acts 2:38-39; 1 Peter 3:21

Pentecostal and Charismatic

Most Pentecostal churches (for example the Assemblies of God and the Foursquare Church) practise believer's baptism by immersion, much as Baptists do: an act of obedience and public testimony by those who have been born again, not a means of salvation. Infants are dedicated, not baptized. Pentecostals give special emphasis to a second, distinct "baptism in the Holy Spirit" (see the lesson on spiritual gifts). A minority ("Oneness" Pentecostals) baptize in the name of Jesus only; most Pentecostals use the threefold name of Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

Key texts: Matthew 28:19; Mark 16:16; Acts 2:38; Acts 8:36-38; Romans 6:4

Teacher note: Encourage the class to describe other traditions' views as their own members would. Many Christians from these traditions worship and serve together and recognise one another as brothers and sisters in Christ.

Discussion questions (5 min)

1. What do all Christians agree about baptism, according to today's passages?

> Jesus commanded it; it is done in the name of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit; it is linked with discipleship, faith and union with Christ; it calls us to new life.

2. Each tradition points to particular verses. Why do sincere Christians reading the same Bible reach different conclusions about baptism?

The New Testament does not answer every question directly (for example, whether the "households" in Acts included infants), so Christians weigh different texts and patterns (covenant continuity, the order of faith and baptism) differently.

3. How can we hold our own convictions about baptism while showing love to Christians who practise it differently?

By being clear about what Scripture teaches as we understand it, listening carefully, describing others fairly, and remembering that we share one Lord and one faith.

4. What does Romans 6 say baptism should mean for the way we live this week?

We have died to sin with Christ and been raised to walk in newness of life; we live as people who belong to him.

Application (2 min)

This week, find out what your own church teaches about baptism and why, and look up the key texts for that view. If you have not been baptized, talk with your pastor. Pray for the unity of Christians who differ on this question.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord Jesus, you commanded your church to make disciples and baptize them in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Thank you for uniting us to yourself in your death and resurrection. Help us walk in newness of life. Where your people understand baptism differently, give us humility, love and a shared desire to be faithful to your word. Amen.

Sources quoted

Joseph Stump, An Explanation of Luther's Small Catechism, “What Baptism is”

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Romans 6:3

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